

So and such

Teaching guide

Add emphasis using the right sentence pattern.

Understand the distinction

Use so before an adjective or adverb: so helpful, so quickly. Use such before a noun phrase: such a helpful person, such helpful people. With a singular countable noun, keep a or an.

Use so with many, much, few, and little when these describe quantities: so many books, so little time. A following that clause can give a result: It was so noisy that I left. Emphasis is a choice, not a factual measurement.

Compare the patterns

ADJECTIVE

The guide was so helpful.

So modifies helpful.

NOUN PHRASE

She was such a helpful guide.

Such introduces the noun phrase.

QUANTITY

There were so many questions.

So combines with many.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: It was ___ a useful lesson.

A. such as

B. so

C. such

2. Complete: The room was ___ quiet.

A. such

B. such a

C. so

3. Choose the correction: We had such much work.

A. We had such many work.

B. We had so much work.

C. We had so many work.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which sentence uses so correctly and gives the result of clear instructions?

- A. The instructions were so clearly that I finished without help.
- B. The instructions were so clear that I finished without help.
- C. The instructions were such clear that I finished without help.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. such

A useful lesson is a noun phrase.

A: Such as introduces examples, not this degree expression.

B: Use such before a noun phrase with a: such a useful lesson.

2. C. so

Quiet is an adjective without a following noun.

A: Before the adjective quiet alone, use so.

B: Such a needs a following noun phrase, such as such a quiet room.

3. B. We had so much work.

Use so before the quantity word much.

A: The pattern is so much work.

C: Work is uncountable in this meaning, so use much rather than many.

4. B. The instructions were so clear that I finished without help.

So modifies the adjective clear; that introduces the result.

A: Were needs the adjective clear for this description, not the adverb clearly.

C: Use so before clear alone, or such clear instructions with a noun.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-40.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which sentence uses *so* correctly and gives the result of clear instructions?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.